

160 Dorcas

The disciple of Joppa whose kindness was so missed that Peter was called to her deathbed.

Dorcas, also called Tabitha, lived in the port town of Joppa. Acts calls her "a certain disciple" and says she "was full of good works and almsdeeds." She made coats and garments for the town's widows, some of the poorest people of her day. When she died, the believers laid her in an upper room and sent for Peter from nearby Lydda. The widows met him in tears, holding up the clothes she had made. Peter knelt, prayed, and said, "Tabitha, arise." She opened her eyes and sat up, and many in Joppa believed. Her story shows how much quiet, practical love matters to God.

At a glance

<i>Names</i>	Aramaic <i>Tabitha</i> , Greek <i>Dorcas</i> : both "gazelle"
<i>Family</i>	Not given
<i>Described as</i>	"A certain disciple," "full of good works and almsdeeds" (Acts 9:36)
<i>When</i>	Probably the late AD 30s
<i>Key places</i>	Joppa; Lydda
<i>Key people</i>	Peter; the widows of Joppa; two messengers; Simon the tanner
<i>Main passages</i>	Acts 9:36–43
<i>New Testament</i>	Named only in Acts 9

"But Peter put them all forth, and kneeled down, and prayed; and turning him to the body said, Tabitha, arise. And she opened her eyes: and when she saw Peter, she sat up."

Acts 9:40, KJV

The life of Dorcas

Acts gives no year. The story comes after Saul's conversion and just before Peter's visit to Cornelius, so it probably happened in the late AD 30s.

Joppa

Before her illness

● **A disciple full of good works**

Tabitha, called Dorcas in Greek, is a believer in Joppa. She is known for her good works and her gifts to the poor. She makes coats and garments for the widows.

Acts 9:36, 39

Joppa

In those days

● **Sickness and death**

Dorcas falls sick and dies. The believers wash her body, as was the custom, and lay her in an upper room instead of burying her at once. *Acts 9:37*

Lydda, nearby

● **A message for Peter**

Hearing that Peter is at Lydda, where he has just healed Aeneas, the disciples send two men. They beg him not to delay in coming to them. *Acts 9:32–35, 38*

The upper room

● **The widows weep**

Peter comes at once. The widows stand beside him weeping, showing him the coats and garments Dorcas made while she was with them. *Acts 9:39*

The upper room

● **Raised to life**

Peter sends them all out, kneels and prays. He says, "Tabitha, arise." She opens her eyes, sees Peter and sits up. He gives her his hand and presents her alive to the saints and widows. *Acts 9:40–41*

Joppa

Afterward

● **Many believe**

The news spreads through all Joppa, and many believe in the Lord. Peter stays many days in the town with Simon, a tanner. *Acts 9:42–43*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Dorcas.

Old Testament

Echoes	Elijah raised the widow of Zarephath's son in an upper room (1 Kings 17:17-24). Elisha shut the door and prayed before the Shunammite woman's son was raised (2 Kings 4:32-37). The good wife of Proverbs "stretcheth out her hand to the poor" (Proverbs 31:20).
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New Testament

Acts 9:36-43	This is the only account of Dorcas.
Echoes	Jesus put the mourners out and said to Jairus' daughter, "Talitha cumi," meaning "Damsel, I say unto thee, arise" (Mark 5:40-41). Peter follows the same pattern. Jesus said, "Naked, and ye clothed me" (Matthew 25:36). "Pure religion and undefiled before God and the Father is this, To visit the fatherless and widows in their affliction" (James 1:27).
Tradition	A traditional burial place of Tabitha is shown in Jaffa today, but it cannot be confirmed.

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the widows show Peter when he arrived (Acts 9:39)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Acts tells us about Dorcas's sewing before it tells us about the miracle?
3. *Apply:* Dorcas used a practical skill to serve others. What skill or resource do you have that could meet a real need this month?
4. *Apply:* Who in your community is like the widows of Joppa, easy to overlook? What is one way you could help them this week?